political map of south India had changed dramatically. A sovereign Muslim kingdom, the Bahmani Sultanate—founded by Bahman Shah, a rebellious general in Tughlak's army—had arisen in mid-peninsula. This kingdom patronized Islam as the religion of its urban centres alongside Persian language and culture. This created both cultural disruptions for some and new opportunities for others. To its south had emerged a powerful new entity, also very militaristic and expansionist: the Vijayanagar Kingdom, founded by two soldiers and brothers, Hakka and Bukka, sons of Sangama, likely a Telugu Shudra chief; though their ethnic lineage is still contested, with some claiming they were Kannadigas.

How did the two Sangama brothers found a new city? Rival accounts exist. One account claims that the two brothers, in the Kakatiya king's employ, were captured by Tughlak and taken to Delhi. The brothers converted to Islam, worked with Tughlak for a few years and imbibed the ways of the sultanate. They gained Tughlak's trust to the point that he sent them back to govern his frontier territories in the south. This began well but one day soon after, the brothers went out hunting. They came across a few hounds pursuing a terrified hare, and then saw a strange sight: the hare suddenly stopped running, turned around and began chasing the hounds instead. A sage, Vidyaranya, promptly appeared and called this a sign from high above, heralding an auspicious location for a great new city. Under the sage's counsel, the brothers betrayed Tughlak's trust, quit his employ, reverted to Hinduism and began building their own kingdom with its new capital, Vijayanagar (City of Victory). It was c. 1336 CE. Tughlak didn't seem to do much about their desertion owing to other distractions and setbacks he faced in the north.

A more mundane account claims that the brothers served a king of Kampili whom Tughlak defeated. The brothers fled and joined the Hoysala king, later gaining control of a fortress of the Kampili king at Anegundi on the Tungabhadra River. They raised an army, likely including Muslim mercenaries, and began amassing territory and building a new capital city across the river, which already had a settlement around the Pampa-Virupaksha Temple.[5] To legitimize their status, they patronized this temple. Virupaksha, now a Shaivite god, became the state deity of their new kingdom. Later, however, they broadened their appeal by patronizing